

Your Photo and Voice

A step-by-step guide for Windows 10, Windows 11 and Mac laptops

This guide helps you make your photos and voice recordings on your own laptop:

- 1 Five photos of your face** (picture files, usually ending in `.jpg`).
- 2 Three short recordings of your voice**, about 4 minutes in total (sound files, usually ending in `.m4a` or `.wav`).

These files are used to create a talking video "skin" for a chatbot. The photo becomes the face, and the recordings teach a computer to speak in a voice that sounds like you. Your recordings are not played back as they are; they are only used as a sample.

What you need

- A laptop with a built-in camera and microphone (almost all laptops have both).
- A quiet room and about 25 minutes.
- A window or lamp in front of you for light.
- This guide, printed or open on a phone or second screen, so you can read the script while recording.

No accounts, downloads or technical skills are needed. Everything uses apps that already come with your laptop.

Which part of this guide is for me?

Every section has separate steps for each kind of laptop. Find yours and follow only those steps.

Windows 10

Photo: **Camera** app
Voice: **Voice Recorder** app

Windows 11

Photo: **Camera** app
Voice: **Sound Recorder** app

Mac

Photo: **Photo Booth** app
Voice: **Voice Memos** app

Not sure which Windows you have? Press the `Windows` key, type **winver** and press `Enter`. A small window shows "Windows 10" or "Windows 11". Click **OK** to close it.

The plan: get the room ready (Part 1), take 5 photos (Part 2), make 3 short voice recordings (Part 3), then find and send your files (Part 4). Allow about 25 minutes in total.

Your permission matters. Only send photos and voice recordings of *yourself*, and only if you are happy for them to be used to make a talking video that looks and sounds like you. Some voice services may later ask you to say a short phrase to confirm that it is really your voice and that you agree.

Part 1. Get ready

For the photo

- **Light in front of you.** Sit facing a window (daytime is best) or a lamp. Do not sit with a bright window behind you, or your face will be dark.
- **Plain background.** A plain wall behind you is ideal.
- **Clean the camera lens.** Gently wipe the small lens above your screen with a soft cloth. Smudges make the photo blurry.
- **Raise the laptop.** Put it on a few books so the camera is at about the height of your eyes, not looking up at your chin.
- **Clear your face.** Take off sunglasses, hats and masks, and move hair away from your eyes. Ordinary glasses are fine, but tilt them slightly if they reflect light.

For the voice recording

- **Quiet room.** Turn off the TV, music, fans, heaters and air conditioning. Close the windows and door. Silence your phone.
- **Soft room is better.** A bedroom with curtains, a bed and carpet sounds much better than a kitchen or bathroom, which echo.
- **Sit close.** Sit about an arm's length from the laptop or a little closer, and stay at the same distance the whole time.
- **Have water nearby.** A sip between sections keeps your voice clear.
- **Plug in the laptop** so it does not go to sleep or run out of battery while you record.

Using a headset or plug-in microphone? That is fine and often sounds better. Plug it in before you open the recording app. Keep it a hand's width from your mouth, a little to the side so your breath does not hit it.

"Allow" messages

The first time you open a camera or recording app, your laptop may ask whether the app can use the camera or microphone. Always click **Allow** or **OK**. If you clicked "Don't allow" by mistake, see the help section at the end of this guide.

Part 2. Take your photos

Take exactly 5 photos

Take these **5 photos, in this order**, without moving the laptop or changing the light between them. Send all 5; the best one will be picked as your "face", and the others help as backups and for small changes of expression.

Photo	Your head	Your face
1	Straight at the camera	Relaxed and neutral, mouth closed . This is the most important photo.
2	Straight at the camera	Relaxed, lips slightly apart (as if about to say "uh"). No teeth showing, or only a little.
3	Straight at the camera	A gentle, closed-mouth smile , the way you smile when greeting someone.
4	Turned slightly to your left , a small turn only (about the angle of glancing at a clock on the wall). Eyes still on the lens.	Relaxed, mouth closed.
5	Turned slightly to your right , the same small amount. Eyes still on the lens.	Relaxed, mouth closed.

If a photo comes out blurry, with eyes closed, or badly lit, simply take that one again. You should end up with 5 good photos.

Photo tips: what matters most

The computer builds a moving face from your photo, so it can only use what it can clearly see. In order of importance:

- 1 Your face fills a good part of the picture.** Head and shoulders only, not your whole upper body. Leave about a hand's width of space above your head and some space on each side, because the face will move slightly in the video and needs room.
- 2 Eyes on the lens, not the screen.** Look at the small camera dot above the screen. Looking at your own face on the screen makes you appear to look down. Keep your eyes open and relaxed, not wide.
- 3 Mouth closed or only slightly open.** The computer creates the mouth movements itself. A big smile or open mouth "freezes" your teeth into every word you say, which looks odd. Save big smiles for another day.
- 4 Soft, even light on both sides of your face.** Face a window or a lamp. Avoid one side of your face being in shadow, bright shiny spots on your forehead, or a bright window behind you.
- 5 Sharp, not blurry.** Hold still for the moment the photo is taken. Clean the lens first.
- 6 Nothing covering your face.** No hands near your face, hair out of your eyes, no hat, sunglasses or mask. Normal glasses are fine if there is no glare on the lenses; tilt them down slightly if there is.
- 7 Camera at eye level.** Raise the laptop on books so the camera is level with your eyes. Sit up straight with your shoulders relaxed and level.
- 8 Plain, tidy background.** A plain wall is best. Avoid busy shelves, mirrors, posters, or other people behind you.
- 9 Look like yourself on a normal day.** Wear what you normally wear (solid colours look better than busy patterns) and your usual hairstyle, glasses and make-up. This is how the video version of you will look.

Part 2 (continued). How to take the photos

Windows 10 and Windows 11: the Camera app

The steps are the same on both.

- 1 Click the **Start** button (the Windows logo in the bottom corner of the screen), or press the Windows key on your keyboard.
- 2 Type the word **Camera**. When the **Camera** app appears in the list, click it.
- 3 If asked "Let Camera access your camera?" or similar, click **Yes** or **Allow**. Your face now appears on the screen.
- 4 Make sure the app is in **photo** mode, not video. On the right side there is a round button with a **camera** picture on it. If it shows a video camera instead, click the small camera icon next to it to switch to photo.
- 5 Sit back so your head and shoulders fit in the picture. Look at the small camera lens above the screen.
- 6 Click the round **Take photo** button. You hear a shutter sound, and a small preview appears in a corner.
- 7 Take the rest of the **5 photos** from the list in Part 2, one after another.
- 8 To look at them, click the small preview in the corner. Close the Camera app when you are done (the **X** at the top right).

Where the photos are saved: in your **Pictures** folder, inside a folder called **Camera Roll**. Part 4 shows how to find them.

Optional, for a sharper photo: in the Camera app click the **gear** icon (Settings). Under **Photo quality** (or **Photo settings**), choose the largest size in the list. Also turn off "Framing grid" if it is getting in your way.

Mac: the Photo Booth app

- 1 Press **Command** + **Space** together. A search bar appears in the middle of the screen.
- 2 Type **Photo Booth** and press **Return**. Your face appears on the screen and a small green light turns on next to the camera.
- 3 In the bottom left corner there are three small buttons. Click the **left one** (a single square) so the app takes **one photo**, not four.
- 4 If you see a button called **Effects**, make sure the picture shows no effect (the middle choice, "Normal").
- 5 Sit back so your head and shoulders fit in the picture. Look at the camera lens above the screen.
- 6 Click the red **camera** button at the bottom. Photo Booth counts down 3, 2, 1, the screen flashes white, and the photo is taken.
- 7 Take the rest of the **5 photos** from the list in Part 2. They appear as small pictures along the bottom.
- 8 Save all 5 photos to the Desktop, one at a time: click a photo in the row at the bottom, then in the menu at the top of the screen choose **File > Export**. Choose **Desktop** as the location, give it a name such as **Photo 1**, and click **Save**. Repeat for the other four.

Another way to save it: simply drag each small picture from the bottom of Photo Booth onto your Desktop.

Part 3. Record your voice

You will make **3 short recordings**, one for each section below. Each one is a separate sound file. Record a section, stop, listen to check it, and only then move on to the next. If a section goes wrong, just record that section again; you never have to start over from the beginning.

Recording	What you say	How long it takes	Name it
1	Read script lines 1 to 10 out loud (page "Recording 1")	About 1½ minutes	Voice 1
2	Read script lines 11 to 19 out loud (page "Recording 2")	About 1½ minutes	Voice 2
3	Answer 2 or 3 questions in your own words, no script (page "Recording 3")	About 1 minute	Voice 3

What the times mean

The times above are the **total length of each whole recording**, from when you press Record to when you press Stop. They are not pauses. All three recordings together come to about 4 minutes of talking.

Pause after each line: about 1 second. Read a line, take one normal breath (about one second), then read the next line. That is all. Do not wait longer than 2 or 3 seconds. The times are only a guide; if your recording is a little shorter or longer, that is fine.

How to speak

- Use your **normal, relaxed voice**, the way you talk to a friend. Not a "presentation" or "telephone" voice.
- Speak at a natural, everyday pace. Don't rush and don't slow down.
- **Small slip?** Don't stop. Pause for a second, then say that line again and carry on.
- **Lots of slips, or a noise (cough, phone, dog)?** Stop, delete that recording, and record that section again.
- Only your voice should be on the recording. Ask others in the house to stay quiet for a few minutes.
- Keep the same distance from the laptop, and stay in the same room, for all three recordings.

Part 3 (continued). How to make each recording

Follow the steps for your laptop. You will repeat the "record, stop, check, rename" steps three times, once for each recording.

First, do a 10-second test

Before the real recording, record yourself saying "Hello, this is a test" and play it back. If it sounds muffled, quiet or echoey, move closer to the laptop or try a different room. Then delete the test or just ignore it.

Windows 10: the Voice Recorder app

- 1 Click **Start** or press the Windows key, type **Voice Recorder**, and click the app when it appears.
- 2 If asked to allow the microphone, click **Yes** or **Allow**.
- 3 Turn to the page for the recording you are making (start with Recording 1).
- 4 Click the big round blue **microphone** button to start recording. A timer starts counting.
- 5 Read that page only. When you reach the end of the page, click the round **Stop** button in the middle. The recording appears in the list on the left.
- 6 Click the recording and press **Play**. Listen to a few seconds at the start and at the end to check it is clear.
- 7 **Rename it:** with the recording selected, click **Rename** (a pencil icon at the bottom of the window, or right-click the recording and choose Rename). Type **Voice 1** (then Voice 2, Voice 3) and press Enter.
- 8 Not happy with it? Right-click it, choose **Delete**, and record that section again.
- 9 Repeat these steps for Recording 2 and Recording 3.

Where the recordings are saved: in your **Documents** folder, inside a folder called **Sound recordings**. Each one ends in .m4a, which is fine. Shortcut: right-click the recording in the list and choose **Open file location**.

Can't find Voice Recorder? Open the **Microsoft Store** app, search for "Windows Voice Recorder" or "Sound Recorder", and click **Get**. It is free.

Windows 11: the Sound Recorder app

- 1 Click **Start** or press the key, type **Sound Recorder**, and click the app when it appears.
- 2 If asked to allow the microphone, click **Yes** or **Allow**.
- 3 **Recommended, one time only:** click the **three dots** (...) in the top right corner and choose **Settings**. Set **Recording format** to **WAV** (if not shown, leave it as it is), and set **Audio quality** to **High** or the best choice listed. Click the back arrow.
- 4 If you use a headset or plug-in mic, pick it from the microphone list at the bottom left of the window. Otherwise leave it as it is.
- 5 Turn to the page for the recording you are making (start with Recording 1).
- 6 Click the big round red **Record** button. A timer starts counting.
- 7 Read that page only. When you reach the end of the page, click the square **Stop** button. The recording appears in the list on the left.
- 8 Click it and press **Play**. Listen to a few seconds at the start and at the end to check it is clear.
- 9 **Rename it:** right-click the recording in the list, choose **Rename**, type **Voice 1** (then Voice 2, Voice 3) and press .
- 10 Not happy with it? Right-click it, choose **Delete**, and record that section again.
- 11 Repeat these steps for Recording 2 and Recording 3.

Where the recordings are saved: in your **Documents** folder, inside **Sound recordings**. Each one ends in or ; either is fine. Shortcut: right-click the recording in the list and choose **Show in folder**.

Mac: the Voice Memos app

- 1 Press `Command` + `Space`, type **Voice Memos**, and press `Return`.
- 2 If asked to allow the microphone, click **OK** or **Allow**.
- 3 **Recommended, one time only:** in the menu at the top of the screen click **Voice Memos** > **Settings** (on older Macs it says **Preferences**). Set **Audio Quality** to **Lossless**, then close that small window.
- 4 Turn to the page for the recording you are making (start with Recording 1).
- 5 Click the big round red **Record** button at the bottom left.
- 6 Read that page only. When you reach the end of the page, click **Done**. The recording appears in the list, usually named after your location or "New Recording".
- 7 Click it and press the **Play** button. Listen to a few seconds at the start and at the end to check it is clear.
- 8 **Rename it:** double-click its name in the list, type **Voice 1** (then Voice 2, Voice 3) and press `Return`.
- 9 Not happy with it? Click it, press the `Delete` key, and record that section again.
- 10 **Do not** click the magic-wand **Enhance Recording** button, and do not add any effects. The plain recording is what is needed.
- 11 Save it to the Desktop: drag the recording from the list onto your Desktop. A file ending in `.m4a` appears there.
- 12 Repeat these steps for Recording 2 and Recording 3. You should end up with 3 sound files on your Desktop.

Please leave "clean-up" features off. Some laptops offer noise reduction, voice clarity, voice focus or "enhance" options. Leave them off or as they are. The plain, natural sound of your voice gives the best result.

Recording 1 of 3. Read this out loud

Before you start: press Record. **Read each line, then pause about 1 second** (one breath) before the next line. **At the end of the page:** press Stop, listen to check it, and name it **Voice 1**. This whole recording takes **about 1½ minutes**.

- 1 Hi, thanks for stopping by. It's good to see you.
- 2 I wasn't sure what to expect today, but honestly, I'm glad you asked.
- 3 Let me think about that for a second. Okay, here's what I'd do.
- 4 First, take a deep breath. Second, write down the three things that matter most. Third, pick one and start there.
- 5 Really? You found it in the garage, behind the old bicycle? That's amazing!
- 6 No, no, that's not what I meant at all. I meant the other one, the blue one.
- 7 The weather this weekend should be cool and breezy, with a chance of rain on Sunday afternoon.
- 8 My favourite meal is still my grandmother's soup, with fresh bread and a little too much butter.
- 9 She sells seashells by the seashore, and the shells she sells are surely seashells.
- 10 The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog, and the dog doesn't seem to mind.

Stop recording here. Check it, name it Voice 1, then turn the page for Recording 2.

Recording 2 of 3. Read this out loud

Before you start: press Record. **Read each line, then pause about 1 second** (one breath) before the next line. **At the end of the page:** press Stop, listen to check it, and name it **Voice 2**. This whole recording takes **about 1½ minutes**.

- 11 Could you call me back around four thirty? My number is five five five, two nine one, eight three zero seven.
- 12 It cost about twelve dollars and fifty cents, which felt fair for what it was.
- 13 Hmm, I'm not totally sure. I think it was in two thousand nineteen, but don't quote me on that.
- 14 Wow. That is genuinely the best news I've heard all week.
- 15 I'm sorry to hear that. That sounds really hard, and it makes sense that you're tired.
- 16 Here's a fun fact: an octopus has three hearts and blue blood.
- 17 Would you like the short version, or the long version with all the details?
- 18 Measure twice, cut once. My father used to say that, and he was usually right.
- 19 Thanks for listening. Take care of yourself, and let's talk again soon.

Stop recording here. Check it, name it Voice 2, then turn the page for Recording 3.

Recording 3 of 3. Talk freely

Before you start: read the questions below and choose **two or three**. Then press Record and answer them out loud in your own words, as if chatting with a friend. There is no script and no right answer. Talk for **about 20 to 30 seconds per question**, so the whole recording takes **about 1 minute**. Pause for a second between questions. **When you finish:** press Stop, listen to check it, and name it **Voice 3**.

- What did you do last weekend?
- Describe a place you love and why.
- Explain how to make something you cook often.
- What's something you've changed your mind about?

Optional extra recording: is English not your first language? If you like, make one more recording of about 1 minute talking about anything in your first language, and name it **Voice 4**. People often sound most relaxed and natural in their own language, and it helps capture the sound of your voice.

Check your recordings

- ☐ You have 3 recordings named Voice 1, Voice 2 and Voice 3 (plus Voice 4 if you made the optional one).
- ☐ Voice 1 and Voice 2 are each about 1 to 2 minutes long; Voice 3 is about 1 minute.
- ☐ When you play them back, your voice is clear and easy to hear.
- ☐ There is no music, TV, other voices or loud background hum.

If one of them went wrong, delete just that one and record that section again.

Part 4. Find your files and send them

You will send **8 files**: your 5 photos and your 3 voice recordings (9 files if you made the optional Voice 4).

Windows 10 and Windows 11

- 1** Open **File Explorer**: click the yellow folder icon on the taskbar at the bottom of the screen, or press the **Windows** key and the **E** key together.
- 2** **Photo**: on the left, click **Pictures**, then open the **Camera Roll** folder. Your 5 photos are the newest ones. Double-click to check them.
- 3** **Recordings**: on the left, click **Documents**, then open the **Sound recordings** folder. You should see Voice 1, Voice 2 and Voice 3.
- 4** **Add your name** to each file so they are easy to recognise (optional but helpful): right-click the file, choose **Rename**, type for example **Maria photo 1** or **Maria Voice 1**, and press **Enter**. Do not change the part after the dot (such as .jpg or .m4a).

Using OneDrive? Sometimes Pictures and Documents are inside a OneDrive folder. If you can't find them, click in the search box at the top right of File Explorer and type **Camera Roll** or **Sound recordings**.

Mac

- 1** All 8 files should now be on your **Desktop** (you put them there in Parts 2 and 3).
- 2** **Add your name** to each file (optional but helpful): click a file once, press **Return**, type a new name such as **Maria photo 1** or **Maria Voice 1**, and press **Return** again. Keep the ending (.jpg, .png or .m4a) as it is.

Sending the files

Send all 8 files to the person who gave you this guide, using whatever you usually use:

- **Email**: start a new email, click the **paperclip** (Attach) button, and choose the 5 photos and the 3 recordings. Most recordings in **.m4a** format are small enough to email.
- **If email says the file is too large** (common with **.wav** files): use a sharing service such as Google Drive, OneDrive, iCloud Drive or Dropbox, or WeTransfer, and send the link instead. Or copy the files to a USB stick.
- **Please send the original files**. Do not send them through WhatsApp, Messenger or text messages, because these shrink and lower the quality of photos and sound.

Final checklist

- ☐ 5 clear photos, as listed in Part 2: three facing the camera (neutral, lips slightly apart, gentle smile) and two turned slightly left and right.
- ☐ 3 voice recordings: Voice 1 (script lines 1 to 10), Voice 2 (script lines 11 to 19) and Voice 3 (your answers to the questions).
- ☐ Both files sent as attachments or a sharing link, not through a chat app.

Thank you! That's all that is needed.

If something goes wrong

Problem	What to try
The camera shows a black screen or "We can't find your camera"	Some laptops have a small sliding cover over the camera, or a camera on/off key on the keyboard (often with a camera picture on it). Slide the cover open or press the key. Close any other app that might use the camera (Zoom, Teams, Skype, FaceTime) and try again.
Windows: I clicked "No" when asked about the camera or microphone	Press the Windows key, type Camera privacy settings (or Microphone privacy settings) and open it. Turn on access, and make sure Camera , Voice Recorder or Sound Recorder is switched on in the list.
Mac: I clicked "Don't Allow"	Click the Apple menu (top left) > System Settings > Privacy & Security . Click Camera or Microphone and switch on Photo Booth or Voice Memos. (On older Macs: System Preferences > Security & Privacy > Privacy.)
The photo is dark or has strong shadows	Turn to face a window or put a lamp behind the laptop, shining toward your face. Turn off bright lights behind you.
The photo is blurry	Wipe the camera lens, sit still, and make sure the room is bright.
The recording timer doesn't move, or playback is silent	Check that the microphone is allowed (see above). If you use a headset, make sure it is plugged in before opening the app. On Windows 11 Sound Recorder, check the microphone chosen at the bottom left.
The recording sounds echoey or noisy	Move to a smaller room with soft furniture, curtains or carpet. A room full of clothes, such as a walk-in closet, works very well. Turn off fans and air conditioning.
I can't find Voice Recorder or Sound Recorder (Windows)	Open the Microsoft Store , search for "Sound Recorder" or "Windows Voice Recorder", and click Get . It is free.
I can't find my files	Windows: open File Explorer and type the file name, Camera Roll or Sound recordings in the search box at the top right. Mac: press Command + Space and type the file name.

Menu names can differ slightly between versions of Windows and macOS. If a button is named a little differently on your laptop, look for the closest match.